

3. You want your agent to wait patiently with you until properties that meet your criteria come online. When and if they come on the market, you then need the agent to pick up the phone, show you the property, and be prepared to make an offer with a fast turnaround time.

Agents will become wary if they sense you won't actually pull the trigger when a good house comes on the market. An agent who conducts twenty showings and submits twenty unreasonably low offers is an overworked and underpaid agent—and asking this of them is not fair. Instead, you need to be ready, willing, and able to make a competitive offer on properties that meet your criteria.

By setting these expectations up front, you're letting the agent know that you need them to perform critical services for you throughout the home-buying process. You're also making it clear that you expect a very reasonable workload overall, since you won't ask them to show you dozens of properties you have no interest in purchasing.

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN PASSABLE AND GREAT

Real estate agents come in all shapes and sizes, and someone who is great for your neighbor might not be great for you. Especially as a first-time home buyer, you need someone who is willing to explain everything as you go, communicate in the way you prefer, and be available when you need them. (And, of course, they should know what they're doing.)

It's not easy finding someone who checks all these boxes, and you're going to have to put in a little work to find them. The best place to start is with recommendations from friends and family—ask anyone who has bought a house recently who they used as their agent and whether they had a good experience. If the answer is “No, my agent never even answered the phone,” there's no need to interview that person.

If the answer is yes, you should contact the agent and set up an initial interview. Whether it's on the phone or in person, you should come prepared with a list of questions, including: